CHAPTER 3

WALT AND THE CABIN

MINNEAPOLIS AND PIKE LAKE · 1956–1968

On Shoes, Sore Feet and a Roof

In 1956 Ruth went down to Minneapolis for three years of nursing school.

The students lived in a dormitory, and the house mother inspected their shoes every morning. "Every morning! As if the patients were going to look at our shoes."

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⟦BRIDGE: Three years later, the thing she remembered best about Minneapolis had nothing to do with nursing.⟧

She met Walt at a church dance in 1959. Walt could not dance at all; he stepped on her feet the whole night and then asked if he could walk her home. "I said, well, my feet can't take much more of this, but all right."

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Starting in 1964 or so, Ruth and Walt built a cabin on Pike Lake with their own hands. It took four summers. Walt did the walls and Ruth did the roof, because Walt was afraid of heights. "Nobody believes that," she said.

ILLUSTRATION (GENERATED): THE CABIN HALF BUILT, ABOUT 1965 ⟦P002⟧

What she valued most about it was simple. “The lake was always there. Whatever else happened, the lake was always there.”